

\$5 OF STEEL WOOL KEEPS THE MICE OUT

Every mouse in your house came in through a gap the width of a pencil. Find the gaps, pack them, lock them in, then trap what is already inside.

THE IDEA IN PLAIN WORDS

A house mouse fits through a hole a quarter inch across, the width of a pencil. The fix, straight from the Centers for Disease Control, is to pack that gap with coarse steel wool and caulk over it.

Mice chew through plastic screening, rubber, vinyl, expanding foam, and wood. Chewing works on a solid that holds still. Steel wool is a loose tangle of thousands of thin, sharp shavings. Bite into it and nothing holds still: the bundle gives and springs back, so the tooth has nothing to grip. The caulk does no blocking on its own. It just holds the wool where you put it.

The pencil test: if a pencil goes into the gap, a mouse can too.



The gap is usually around the pipe, not the pipe itself.

MOUSE NUMBERS THAT MATTER

1/4 inch	The gap a house mouse squeezes under. They also fit through an opening 3/8 of an inch wide.
12 inches	How high they jump straight up from the floor. They also climb any rough wall and run along wires. A roofline gap is as good as a foundation gap.
30 feet	House mice seldom travel farther than this from the nest and the food. Keep that in mind when you set traps.
5 to 6 weeks	Age when a female can breed. She can have 5 to 10 litters a year, with 5 or 6 pups in each.
21 million	United States homes invaded by rodents each winter, per the National Pest Management Association.

WHAT IT COSTS

about \$5	A 12 pad pack of steel wool.
about \$10	The steel wool plus a tube of caulk.
\$40 to \$80	A full job with copper mesh for wet gaps, metal patches for big holes, and traps.
\$150 to \$550	One exterminator visit. Cost guides put a typical mouse job around \$350, follow up visits at \$75 to \$125 each, and sealing is often billed separately.

Trapping clears the mice inside. The open gap lets the next one in. A California pest note calls exclusion the most successful and permanent form of house mouse control.

SHOPPING LIST

- ☐ **Coarse steel wool**, grade 3 or 4 on the pack. A 12 pad pack runs about \$5. Skip the fine grades marked with zeros.
- ☐ **Caulk**. Exterior grade for outside gaps. Near copper or brass pipes, check the label first, because some silicone sealants corrode them.
- ☐ **Gloves, scissors, and a screwdriver** to cut and pack the wool.
- ☐ **Woven copper mesh** or a stainless steel fiber plug for gaps that get wet.
- ☐ **Hardware cloth with a quarter inch mesh**, tin snips, and screws for holes wider than about half an inch.
- ☐ **Door sweeps** and a replacement garage door seal where needed.
- ☐ **Weep hole covers** for brick, and a **flap style dryer vent cover**.
- ☐ **Flashlight, a pencil, and painter's tape** for the walk around.
- ☐ **At least a dozen plain snap traps** and a jar of peanut butter.
- ☐ **Rubber gloves, bleach, paper towels, and bags** for cleanup.
- ☐ **Glass, metal, or heavy plastic containers** for your food.



Roll a plug a little bigger than the hole and pack it until the screwdriver stops.

THE WALK AROUND

Daylight, flashlight for the shadows. Push the pencil into every gap. Mark each one with painter's tape.

- ☐ **Outside, ground level:** where siding meets the concrete, every hole where a pipe, cable, gas line, or wire enters, the dryer vent, crawl space vents, torn or missing vent screens.
- ☐ **Doors:** garage door bottom corners where the seal is worn, door sweeps on every exterior door, weather stripping around windows.
- ☐ **Then look up:** rafters, gables, eaves, and soffits. Soffit corners, where a gutter bracket meets the fascia, where two roof pitches meet. Mobile home skirting all the way around.
- ☐ **Inside:** the drain pipe hole under the kitchen sink, the wall behind the stove and fridge (ease them out slowly so you do not strain a gas or water line), closets, fireplace, floor vents, floor drains, and the line holes at the water heater and furnace.
- ☐ **Attic and basement:** where the ceiling meets the wall, and where any pipe passes through a floor.
- ☐ **Signs of use:** small dark droppings, and fresh gnaw marks about 1/32 of an inch wide that look lighter than old weathered wood.

PACK THE GAP

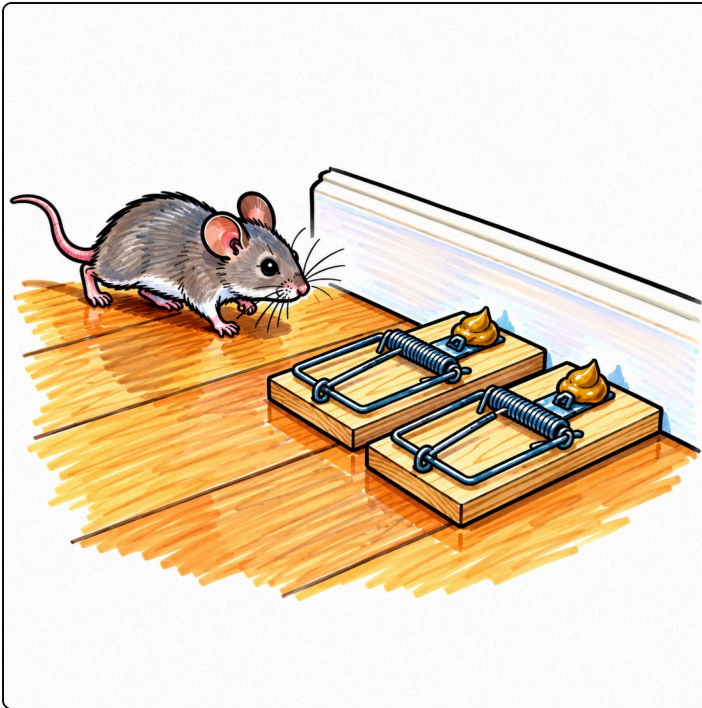
- 1 Wear gloves. Cut a piece off the pad with scissors.
- 2 Roll it into a plug a little bigger than the hole.
- 3 Push it in with a screwdriver until it is packed tight and the screwdriver stops. Push in another piece. If it squishes when you press it, it is too loose.
- 4 Leave it a little short of flush so the caulk has somewhere to sit.
- 5 Caulk over the plug and press the caulk into the wool with a wet finger. If you use foam, foam over the wool, never instead of it.
- 6 Gaps wider than about half an inch: screw quarter inch hardware cloth over the hole instead.

WHERE STEEL WOOL DOES NOT GO

- ☐ **Wet gaps:** steel wool rusts, so it is a good temporary plug. A wet outside gap rusts through in a season or two. Use copper mesh or stainless fiber.
- ☐ **Dryer vent:** never stuffed, never screened. Use a flap cover that swings shut when the dryer is off.
- ☐ **Brick weep holes:** they drain water out of the wall. Use a weep hole cover made for the job.
- ☐ **Furnace and water heater vents:** leave them alone.
- ☐ **Electrical boxes and wiring:** steel wool conducts electricity. Keep it away.

ORDER OF OPERATIONS

- 1 Seal the outside gaps first. Mice still inside are now cut off from the outside.
- 2 Leave the inside gaps open for now, so mice in the walls come out to the traps.
- 3 Set at least a dozen plain snap traps along walls, in dark corners, and behind objects. Trigger end against the wall.
- 4 A small dab of peanut butter only. Too much lets a mouse lick it clean without tripping the trap.
- 5 Space traps no more than 10 feet apart. Set pairs an inch or two apart to catch the jumpers.
- 6 Keep traps out of reach of kids and pets. Skip poison indoors: a poisoned mouse dies inside the wall.
- 7 Check traps every day. Keep them set until a full week passes with no catch and no fresh droppings.
- 8 Then plug the inside gaps you marked.
- 9 Move food into glass, metal, or heavy plastic containers.
- 10 Check outside plugs every spring and fall. Replace any that rusted or got pulled loose.



Mice hug walls. Pairs of traps, trigger ends against the wall.

CLEANUP RULES (CDC)

- ☐ Do not sweep and do not vacuum. Both put dried droppings into the air, and that is how the virus spreads.
- ☐ Open doors and windows, then leave the room for 30 minutes before you start.
- ☐ Put on rubber gloves. Mix 1 and 1/2 cups of bleach into a gallon of water.
- ☐ Spray droppings and nest until soaking wet. Wait 5 minutes.
- ☐ Wipe up with paper towels, bag it, and put the bag in a covered can.
- ☐ Trapped mouse: spray the mouse and the trap with the bleach mix, wait 5 minutes, bag it.
- ☐ Wash gloved hands with soap before taking the gloves off, then wash bare hands.

SAFETY. NOT OPTIONAL.

- ☐ Very fine steel wool can light from a spark or from touching both terminals of a battery. Buy coarse grade 3 or 4.
- ☐ The fibers cut skin. Wear gloves.
- ☐ Chewed wiring? Stop and call an electrician. Many fires of unknown origin are believed to be caused by rodents gnawing wires.
- ☐ Mice carry salmonella. About 5 percent of United States house mice carry a virus spread through urine, droppings, and saliva. Deer mice around rural homes and cabins can carry hantavirus.

CALL A PRO WHEN

- ☐ The entry is at the roofline and you are not steady on the ladder.
- ☐ The attic has a thick layer of droppings. Hire the cleanup.
- ☐ It is rats: use hardware cloth and sheet metal, not wool, and rat sized traps.
- ☐ It is a bat. Do not seal anything, because sealing traps them inside. Bat removal is a wildlife pro's job.

Watch the full video: youtube.com/@SketchySurvival101

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Subscribe so the next cold snap does not bring the mice in with it.